In some states, like Kerala and Bihar, outmigration rates are among the highest in the world. There is also clear evidence that work-related migration rates increased since the 1990s, coinciding with increased economic growth rates and the globalization of the Indian economy.

The duration of work-related migration matters greatly in understanding the geography of migration in India. The shortest duration migrations of less than a day or a week are called commuting and affect over 10 million people around major urban centres.[99] Slightly longer duration migrations known as seasonal migrations occur, by survey definitions, in spells of a few months each, with no spell lasting more than six months. The word 'seasonal' refers to the gap in the agricultural calendar where people begin to migrate outside for work, usually between November and April. These are India's most vulnerable migration streams affecting 5 per cent of households and over 10 million migrants.[100] Relatively poorer and landless households, STs and the Scheduled Castes (SCs), are over-represented in this form of migration that is often mediated by contractors.[101] Prominent clusters of seasonal outmigration occur in India's tribal belts in central India —at the borders of Gujarat, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh, in southern Odisha and Telangana, northern Karnataka, southern Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh and also in Bihar and Jharkhand. In these areas, nearly a third of the households are directly affected by seasonal migration. In Dohad in Gujarat or Dindori in Madhya Pradesh, one in two households sends out seasonal migrants. These migrations are both rural to rural and rural to urban as a third of the seasonal migrants in India work in the construction sector, a fifth in agricultural activities and a sixth in manufacturing activities.[102] While seasonal migration is male-dominated in nature, it is not uncommon to see women and children working in specific sectors such as construction and brick kilns. Seasonal migrants also live in makeshift tents, huts and camps around worksites, if not in urban slums, under informal contracts and with constant threats of eviction.

Permanent migration lies at the other end of the spectrum of work-related migration, accounting for tens of millions of Indians. Here, the movements are largely rural to urban or urban to urban and are over-represented by the